

Blacksburg Museum And Cultural Center
204 Draper Rd SW,
Blacksburg, VA 24060

April 28, 2025

Victoria Pitrelli, Executive Director
Richard S. Reynolds Foundation
1403 Pemberton Road, Suite 102
Richmond, VA 23238

Subject: Grant Inquiry for African American Preservation Exhibit - Blacksburg Museum And Cultural Center

Dear Mrs. Pitrelli,

We are writing to express our interest in applying for a grant from the Blacksburg Museum and Cultural Center to support our proposed project, "African American Preservation Exhibit" which aims to preserve and restore historic landmarks, buildings, and streets. The Blacksburg Museum and Cultural Foundation is able to inform locals and bring awareness to the rich history of Blacksburg and what it means to be standing here today. This is important for the Blacksburg community because it enriches and teaches visitors about the importance of Blacksburg history and should not be forgotten.

Overview of Blacksburg Museum and Cultural Center:

The BMCC is a non-profit organization dedicated to preserving Blacksburg history, culture, and art all while strengthening the Blacksburg community. By preserving and restoring historic landmarks, buildings, streets, the Blacksburg Museum and Cultural Foundation is able to inform locals and bring awareness to the rich history of Blacksburg and what it means to be standing here today. The museum aims to get more town residents involved in the acknowledgment and knowledge of Blacksburg history so they may better understand the significance of the stones they walk on, streets they live on, and buildings they pass by each day. We have a proven track record of serving the township, locals, visitors, students, parents, and the youth in Blacksburg, Virginia through showcasing local art, honoring and respecting local history, and hosting many community events for the township.

Community Need:

The history and contributions of African Americans in the town of Blacksburg are not as fully represented as they should be. This underrepresentation is a deeply concerning reality that directly impacts the town's growth, cultural richness, and community resilience. It is imperative that we take deliberate steps to showcase, honor, and preserve the legacy of the African American community that has played a pivotal role in shaping the history and development of Blacksburg.

Recognizing and uplifting this important history is essential not only for educating and inspiring future generations but also for paying tribute to the resilience, achievements, and self-reliance demonstrated by the African American community over time. Their contributions have significantly

influenced the social, economic, and cultural fabric of Blacksburg, and it is our responsibility to ensure that these stories are told, celebrated, and preserved.

By highlighting African American history, we instill a sense of pride, identity, and continuity within the community. It provides younger generations with a deeper understanding of their heritage and the diverse narratives that form the foundation of their hometown. This initiative will serve not only as a vital educational resource but also as a meaningful act of recognition and respect toward a community whose impact has often been overlooked.

Addressing this gap in representation is essential for fostering a more inclusive and equitable community, and it aligns with broader efforts to build a town that truly reflects the contributions and histories of all its residents.

Teaching historical events

Project Description:

Our proposed project, "African American Preservation Exhibit," will not only teach new people about the history of the African American community within New Town Blacksburg but allow people to actually connect with what life was like for this community in the time of segregation and injustice. We have recently renovated St. Luke & Odd Fellows Hall and it is in need of funds for signage and exhibits. The building has recently been renovated and is in need of interactive elements that pay proper respect to the history of the location and people. This building is a crucial historic site, as it is the last standing building of New Town, which was the home of a segregated community during the post Civil War era. St. Luke & Odd Fellows Hall served as the center of this segregated community during this time as a dance hall, funeral center, and community meeting place. One interactive exhibit element the museum wants to bring to life is to have recordings of the former residents of New Town telling the story of their experiences with the building and townspeople, which would play by associated artefacts and history boards when activated.

Expected Outcomes:

Through this project, we anticipate achieving the following measurable outcomes to calculator the impact on the community:

- The measurable number of how many new visitors we receive to learn African American history through the exhibit, through sign in sheets.
- The calculated donations we receive through new visitors and memberships.

Budget Summary:

The total project budget is 3,000, with funding requested from your organization totaling 4,000. The funds will be used for painting the wall of St. Luke & Odd Fellows Hall exhibit boards, technological showcases, interactive learning experiences, and showroom lighting.

Conclusion:

We believe that this project aligns perfectly with the goals of Richard S. Reynolds Foundation and has the potential to significantly impact African American History preservation for future generations in Blacksburg, Virginia. We are confident in our ability to execute this project effectively and are eager to discuss this proposal further.

Sincerely,
Lucia Lorenz
Executive Director
Blacksburg Museum and Cultural Center